

adopt new unstable and potentially useless technologies, which are received with much appreciation by other communities and distros in the *nix world, e.g., 'Systemd', a fairly worthless upgrade from the existing 'system V-like' *init* systems widely implemented currently in almost all distros.

Slackware, however, hasn't yet addressed this issue officially but there has been general chatter on the IRC and mailing lists about it, and it's a unanimous belief among all users and developers that it will not switch to a worthless upgrade when it has already implemented a beautifully working, run level system.

Slackware is not about being compatible with the rest of the world or having the most user-friendly workflow or ease of use. For that matter, Slackware is wrongly portrayed as an 'advanced user only' distro and that the community built around it consists of advanced users. Slackware, however, is supported primarily by the 'grand-dads' who are caring yet cranky enough to make you the future *nixers who will succeed them as the graybeards of Slackware.

The installation media can be acquired from <http://www.slackware.com/getslack/>. I, however, preferred getting the DVD image for my architecture amd64, for testing the installation on all three of my trusted machines — my ThinkPad x120e, ThinkPad x201s and MacBook Pro 2010.

The installer for Slackware is based on *ncurses*, which gives the retro look to this distro and appeals to users because of the kind of simplicity it provides. The installer requires you to partition your disks with *cfdisk* or *fdisk* utilities, which are certainly more geeky and not as simple as *gparted* or an automatic partitioning tool shipped with most beginner distros. KDE is the default DE for Slackware, but *xfce* and other WMs are shipped with the DVD image too. Thus it is easy enough to skip installing anything.

You can choose the exact packages you want for installation, individually, or you can choose from categories; even a Net install is possible but is not always the most feasible thing to do.

The best thing about the DVD image is that it contains all the officially packaged software that Slackware provides from its core infrastructure. Frankly, it contains all the tools I need for my work flow, not to mention the 'pkg' package management toolkit, which is actually just a clever way of using 'make-install'. This specific feature of Slackware makes it the best package there is for my personal needs.

However, users who are not so comfortable with packaging and maintaining builds of software for themselves can rely on newly established services for Slackware users such as 'slackbuilds.org' and 'slapt-get', which acts a lot like the Debian 'apt'. In

my opinion, though, the use of such tools robs you of the advantage that Slackware provides you, which is a clean slate to build on and maintain. To quote Patrick Volkerding, "Slackware is designed and developed in such a way that if you wanna compile/rebuild a part of it, it'll not fight/oppose you in the process and will gladly surrender to your changes."

The Slackware philosophy is a lot like that of the BSD operating systems of today—the automation of maintenance tasks to make the user's life easier while also making it simpler for them to tweak the system. And how can I forget the love the distro has for LILO, the long forgotten boot loader, which is the default on Slackware and which worked flawlessly on the MBR formatted disks on my ThinkPads but made me cry my eyes out on the GPT set-up on my MacBook Pro.

Excerpts from my journal regarding my experience with Slackware.

Day 1

Downloaded Slackware current distro tree to build my own image for installation, using Pat's script for building a custom ISO image. Ran the following as the root:

```
isohybrid </path/to/the/.iso>
```

This command needs the package 'Syslinux', which is a modern boot loader found in almost all distro's repos and used for booting live images of distros like *buntus, Fedora and Manjaro.

I was running Debian with Syslinux installed and I created a hybrid image for my own use. Thus I can vouch for Debian being able to do it. After this, I got a flash drive and dd this hybrid image on to it, and ran the following command as root:

```
dd if=/path/to/.iso of=/dev/sdb
```



Note: /dev/sdb is the device node of your flash drive. Check and verify the exact node your USB flash drive is on, with the following command:

```
fdisk -l
```

After booting from the USB on my ThinkPad x120e I saw a root prompt and ran:

```
mkdir adivityainstallsslackware && mount /dev/sdb  
adivityainstallsslackware
```

After this, the installation was quite straightforward with choosing the keyboard layout, the disk partitioning which I had to do manually with *cfdisk*, and then selecting partitions on which to install *swap*, / and *home*.